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Governor Signs Landmark Legislation to Combat Antisemitism in K-12 Schools

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Gov. Gavin Newsom has signed AB 715, landmark legislation aimed at addressing rising antisemitism in California's K-12 schools, according to an announcement from the bill's lead authors.

The bipartisan measure, authored by Assemblymember Rick Chavez Zbur (D-Hollywood) and Assemblymember Dawn Addis (D-Morro Bay), passed both legislative chambers without a single "no" vote. The bill was co-authored by Assemblymember Mike Fong (D-Alhambra), Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), Senator Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco), Senator Lena Gonzalez (D-Long Beach), and Senator Akilah Weber Pierson (D-San Diego).

AB 715 was the only priority bill for the California Legislative Jewish Caucus and addresses what officials describe as an alarming rise in antisemitic incidents. While Jewish people comprise approximately 3% of California's population, anti-Jewish hate crimes accounted for 15% of all hate crimes in 2024, according to the announcement.

The Anti-Defamation League reported a 893% increase in antisemitic hate crimes nationwide over the past decade, with a significant surge following the Oct. 7, 2023, terrorist attack on Israel.

The legislation establishes an Office of Civil Rights featuring multiple coordinators, including an antisemitism prevention coordinator. These positions will assess discrimination in schools, provide recommendations to the Legislature, governor and school districts, and equip educators with tools to support all students.

"Every student deserves to be safe, valued, and respected — no matter who they are or what they believe," Zbur said in a statement. "At a time when hate is rising and antisemitism is sweeping our communities, AB 715 reaffirms California's commitment to inclusion and standing up against bigotry in all its forms."

Addis, who described herself as "a mom and a teacher," called the legislation "a historic first in the nation effort" centered on children's wellbeing.

Jewish Caucus Co-Chairs Gabriel and Wiener said California is "sending a strong and unambiguous message — hate has no place in our schools and will not be tolerated."

David Bocarsly, executive director of JPAC, the bill's sponsor, called it "more than policy" but "a promise that Jewish children, their families, and all students, deserve a great public education and classrooms free from hate and discrimination."

The law takes effect Jan. 1, 2026.

Edited by SMDP Staff

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